

Episode 149: Long Ago... 88 1995 Part 8 Birth of First TV "Colour Design" at Toei in April

Breaking news! There are only 10 days left this year! (big sweat)

Several happy things in such a busy December.

First. In this year's Agency for Cultural Affairs Media Arts Festival Animation Division, *The Tatami Galaxy*, which I participated in, amazingly won the Grand Prize! Grand Prize! I hear it's the first time a TV series work has won the Grand Prize. Director Yuasa's second win since winning the Grand Prize for *Mind Game*. Amazing!

Second. *Strong World One Piece Film* was selected for the 34th Japan Academy Prize Excellence in Animation Award. The recent terrestrial TV premiere also recorded high ratings, so we're aiming for "Best Picture Award" next February!

It makes me genuinely happy when work we've all worked hard on gets recognised like this!

Anyway.

The last *Dragon Ball Z*, theatrical *Dragon Ball Z: Dragon Fist Explosion!! If Goku Won't Do It, Who Will?* In parallel with that production, another job was actually moving. Time returns to April. Around the time of "Golden Week next week!" That day I was called to the meeting room next to the planning and sales department room on the 3rd floor of Oizumi Studio.

"We're doing a series called *Neighbourhood Story* for one year as the programmes following *Marmalade Boy*, which is currently airing Sunday mornings. So, we'd like to ask Tsujita-kun to handle the 'colour' part!" With a voice that carries well like a voice actor's - Producer Seki Hiromi.

A TV series offer! In front of me were Producer Seki Hiromi-san, Series Director Umezawa Atsutoshi-san, and Production Manager Kazama Atsunori-san. On the table were the *Neighbourhood Story* manga main story - pages torn from comic magazines and bound together - and the TV animation *Neighbourhood Story* proposal.

Following Seki-san's words, Series Director Umezawa Atsutoshi-san continued. "This work has fashion occupying a very important position. We want to show the protagonists changing clothes every single episode. So instead of leaving it to colour direction staff like previous TV shows, we want you to properly consider the entire programmes and coordinate the 'colour.'"

Previous Toei TV series each had different approaches for each series. For example, in *Goldfish Warning!* that I previously participated in, after I compiled all main character colours during programmes startup, guest character colours appearing in each episode were decided and used by that episode's director and assigned colour direction (色指定) staff. Actually, that tends to make "colour" directions somewhat scattered. That episode might be OK, but when this character appears in other episodes, it sometimes lacks balance.

What I was offered this time was essentially not just main character colours, but comprehensive colour design for everything - all main character costume changes and guest characters and items appearing in each episode, and all comprehensive colour design for parts relating to the main story content - unified and compiled by me. And that was exactly the job called "colour design" (色彩設計).

"Yes! Please let me do it!" I said.

However, there was also a big problem. Ideally, doing colour direction for all episodes throughout the series would be least problematic, but actually, as a company, I was

somewhat "theatrical work personnel," and several theatrical works were already scheduled through the next year.

"So, since Tsujita-kun has to handle other theatrical works, we'll have someone else handle colour direction, and create a job type? or position for handling colour settings - 'colour design' - so please handle it in that capacity."

What!? I never imagined what I was thinking would come from Seki-san's mouth! Umezawa-san and Kazama-san seemed to have the same thinking. The discussion was already properly established.

At this moment, the first "colour design" in Toei Animation's long TV series history was born.

For a long time, I'd been particular about credits representing our job content and somehow got "colour direction" created in the work's ending credits. That was finally taking hold, and the next stage I'd been aiming for was naturally "colour design." And above all, this new "colour" position - the way "colour design" should be - would become an indicator for "colour" work in future Toei works.

Even so, ah, a TV series! I like working on theatrical works projected on big screens, but still, TV series! And getting such a chance! My feelings, my heart, inevitably raced.

"So... Eh? *Neighbourhood Story*... you said?"

Of course I'd never read it. "What kind of work is it..." I was wondering when Seki-san said:

"So, this weekend we're going to Shueisha to meet the original creator Yazawa-sensei, so keep your schedule open!"

Neighbourhood Story had already started moving considerably toward September broadcast.

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